

I. Energizers and Warm-Ups (E/WUs)

Note: S = students and T = teacher throughout this chapter.

Creativity pioneer Paul Torrance considered warm-ups essential to creative thinking (Kim, 2009a). E/WUs are invaluable to motivate, relax, and increase concentration and focus and develop self-control. In addition, they stimulate higher thinking needed for creative problem solving, such as categorical thinking needed to make connections and draw conclusions. Furthermore, many involve warming up the body, face, and voice. Some start with echoing, before a creative challenge is introduced. Energizers from other chapters work to prepare for drama work, too, especially those in dance. See the Responsive Classroom website for videos of energizers.

Greetings! Everyone mills around until the leader says, "Greet." Everyone greets one another in different ways. T can suggest roles or dispositions; Pretend you are long-lost friends or from another culture (e.g., Japan, France). Use a tambourine to start and stop action.

Wiggle Worms. S finds a personal space. T mimes opening a jar of worms and tells S to get ready to grab them. The leader tosses the worms and directs the S to catch, eat, and become wiggle worms. On "freeze" cue, S stop. Repeat this activity with half the class being the audience who gives feedback. Then reverse. *Variation:* Call out body parts that become "infected." (Jeff Jordan, Ashley River)

Hand Study. (Observation/Icebreaker). Partners take turns examining each other's hands. T tells them to see and feel everything that is unique. *Variation:* Use as a "get to know you" activity: "This is Joe. He has very thick hands with short fingernails. His hands are tan as if he works outside a lot."

Play Ball. (Focus/Concentration). Form a circle. T holds an imaginary ball (show size with hands) and calls someone's name before throwing, as in, "Sue, basketball." The receiver then says, "Thank you, basketball." Play continues, with each receiver calling a new name and throwing the pretend basketball. After a few rounds, T introduces a second ball, saying, "Joe, beach ball," and Joe catches and responds, "Thank you, beach ball." Continue to add more balls. At the end, call "stop" and ask everyone with a ball to hold it. The audience guesses the ball by its size and how it is held.

Concentration. (Visualizing). Make a tray of items. Direct S to mentally picture/study items for ten seconds. Cover the tray. S then list all they can remember. *Variation:* S close their eyes and an item is removed or rearranged; they figure out the change. Use small wipe-off boards so everyone can write the missing item and simultaneously display boards.

Line Up. Ask S to list ways to line up, giving a few examples such as alphabetically, by birthday, or by height. T chooses from the list and S line up accordingly. Periodically, stop and ask S to interview those around them to find out three things about one another. *Variation:* Give directions for groups to go to north, south, east, or west locations such as "redheads take the north wall."

Tongue Tanglers. (Verbal Fluency). First, T says each twister slowly and the group echoes. Next, practice individually and in pairs or go around a circle. Make into a game where play begins over if a person mispronounces. *Examples:* "A hot cup of coffee from a proper copper coffee pot." "Aluminum linoleum." "Bugs black blood." "Six sick sheep." "Unique New York." Find more in *Six Sick Sheep* (Cole, 1993) and websites. *Follow-up:* Students collect and create twisters. Organize alphabetically in a recipe box. Put up a Twister Master chart to keep track of ones they say three times without error. Challenge S with longer twisters such as "Peter Piper." (Schwartz's *A Twister of Twists: A Tangler of Tongues* [1972] offers the history of this classic.)

Finger/Hand Plays. (Concentration). Teach and perform finger plays such as "The Itsy Bitsy Spider." (There are many variations such as Little Richard's high energy CD.) Here is an example fingerplay: Sit on the floor and say, "I relax and focus" (point to self with thumb and lay hands in lap). "I gather in the good" (gather with hands brought in). "I push out the bad" (push outward with both hands). "I celebrate the joy all around me" (raise hands, spread fingers, and do a silent cheer). *Challenge:* Ask S for creative motions or collaboratively write new versions.

One Word at a Time. Sit in a circle. The first person says one word to start a sentence. Then the next person adds a word, and so on. The goal is to make as long a "sensical" sentence as possible.

Sound/Action Stories. (Close Listening). The narrator tells a story while children echo lines and do actions. "Going on a Bear Hunt" is an example, and is accompanied by a walking rhythm. Between sections, give time for S to mime. When the bear is seen, actions are reversed—double time. Another example of a sound/action story appears later in the chapter in Ready Reference 9.3. *Challenge:* Ask S for action and sound options.

Scavenger Hunt. (Categories). Challenge groups to find items in a set time such as "In five minutes find a silky item, a book with an r-controlled word, something that moves, and something that can be used to create." Items can be collected or written down. *Variation:* Organize searches by five senses: "Find something that looks like _____, sounds like _____, feels like _____."

Word Change. (Fluency). Sit in a circle. The first person says a sentence, such as "Mary had a little lamb." The next person repeats the sentence, but changes one word: "Mary had a little goat." Keep going all the way around. *Challenge:* Reverse and slowly return the sentence to its original form.

Sound Alikes. (Close Listening). The goal is to form groups by having S find those who sing the same song or sound. Make cards containing sounds or song titles. For example, do five different titles on five sets of cards for 25 students. Pass them out and begin.

Two Facts/One Lie. S list three facts about themselves. One item is false. S read aloud items. The audience applauds to show which one they believe is the lie. *Note:* Discuss how to be creative without being obvious.

Animal-Car-Flower. (Metaphoric Thinking/Icebreaker). S write down the three categories and an example that applies to them. For example, "My name is _____ and I identify with a cat because _____, a Jeep because _____, and roses because _____." *Variation:* Change categories: water, land, buildings, music, furniture, and fruit.

Reverse Web. (Team Builder). Form small groups, each with a piece of large paper so everyone can write. One person draws a big circle in the center with a short leg coming out for each person. Each of the S writes his/her name on one web leg. Discuss what the group has in common and write/draw results in the center. The more unusual the better (e.g., all like broccoli).

Pass and Pretend. (Creative Thinking/Visual Imagery). Sit in a circle. Pass around an object (scarf). Challenge S to use it creatively by imagining what it can become. For example, a scarf could be rocked like a baby. Encourage using details in action (see "Invisible Object Mime"). *Variation 1:* Do without a prop and ask S to imagine an object, such as a pen, and pantomime using it. The first S passes it to the next, who must use the same object but then transform it into something else. *Variation 2:* Pass an object (e.g., straw) saying, "This is not a straw, it's a _____." The receiver demonstrates how it has transformed.

Character Voices. (Fluency). Ask S to list various characters and write them on cards. Then create a list of random sentences: "Hi, how are you?" "Can you tell me how to get to the nearest hospital?" "We've really been having bad weather lately." "I'm so tired." Place the cards in a basket. Go around with each S drawing a card and saying one of the sentences, in character. Peers tell what message and feelings they heard and any clues to who it is. For example, Santa might laugh between his words or phrases.

Laugh Contest. (Focus/Control). A panel tries to resist laughing as one classmate has a go at telling jokes, making faces, and the like. Discuss school-appropriate humor beforehand. *Challenge:* Create individual joke books by collecting and writing prior to the contest. Research how excellent joke tellers use timing, voice, and so on.

Belly Laughs. (Team Builder). Everyone lies on the floor with his/her head on someone else's belly. At a signal, someone says "ha" and the "ha" travels around the circle. When it gets around, someone else starts a different laugh (e.g., "he he").

Noiseless Sounds. Brainstorm ways to pantomime sounds without making any noise: laugh, applause, choke, sneeze. *Variation:* Ask S to divide the sound into three consecutive pantomime actions such as steps in a sneeze. Groups practice and present to the class.

What's Different? (Concentration/Details). Pair S and label as A and B. A faces B and concentrates on details of B's appearance. T signals and pairs turn back to back. B makes a change. Pairs turn around, and A gets three guesses to figure out "what's different." Then B takes a turn.

Bell Tolls. (Category Game). This requires fast thinking and movement. Give each S a 1/2-inch piece of masking tape. Make a circle. An "IT" goes to the center. Everyone else stands on his/her tape. IT says, "The bell tolls for anyone who _____," and plugs in a category (plays an instrument, knows Picasso's first name). Everyone who fits the category must move to a new spot, while IT tries to get a tape spot. Whoever is without a spot is the new IT. Alternatively, IT may shout "tornado" (instead of a category) and everyone must move to a new spot, but not right next door. Adapt for any unit such as states (e.g., knows the capital of Maine).

Name Sock. (Concentration/Icebreaker). Make two balls using knotted scarves or socks. Stand in a circle and explain the purpose is to learn names. Ask each S to say his/her name with class echoing. T then models how the game works by saying his/her name and the name of a S to whom he/she then throws one ball. Then S says his/her own name and another person's as in "Claudia to Charles," and then throws to that S and so forth. When things are going well, T throws out a second sock ball. *Variation:* Each S takes an alias (e.g., book character, famous person).

Hot Sock. (Categories). Make a set of alphabet or general category cards and tie a knotted sock. Sit in a circle with IT in the center. IT closes his/her eyes and throws the sock. At will, IT says "Stop." The S caught with the sock passes it to the S to the right who holds it. IT draws a card and reads it aloud. The sock is now passed, person to person, around the circle while the "caught" A tries to name five items in a category such as "things that start with B." Vary number as appropriate.

Here's Looking at You, Kid. (Icebreaker). Standing in a circle, everyone looks at the floor. When T calls out, "Look up!" each S must look directly into the eyes of another S. Most of the time, the S looked at won't be looking back, but a few S will make eye contact so they point and say, "Here's looking at you, kid," and exchange places in the circle.

Voice Stunts. (Focus). Form groups of four. Give each a phrase. For example, "To be or not to be," "Zig-zag-zog," or "Slip-slap-slop." Each S says one word in the phrase and then passes the play using eye contact or pointing.

Stunts and Tricks. (Confidence). Students research and perform stunts; for example, rub stomach and pat head simultaneously, balance balloon on the end of the nose, stand with left shoulder and side of left foot snug against a wall and try to raise right leg. See Goodman's *Magic and the Educated Rabbit* (1981) and Randi's *The Magic World of the Amazing Randi* (1989) for more ideas.

Boring Words. (Fluency). Brainstorm dull words (e.g., *cardboard, the, dust, box*) and put in a basket. Form circle. Draw one word and go around with each S saying it "interestingly" by altering dynamics (volume), tempo (rate), pitch, pause, and stress. *Variation:* Collect boring phrases and sentences for this activity.

Ways to Celebrate. Create variations on ways to celebrate good ideas such as *Examples:* Standing ovation, pat on the back, mime exploding firecrackers. *Example:* Chant and mime, "Pat, pat, pat, on the back, back, back, for a job well done. Altogether now . . . REPEAT."

Stage Directions. (Quick thinking and concentration). Do in an open space to teach stage directions, which are from the *actor's* viewpoint: stage right, stage left, and center stage. Designate the stage area and use tape to line off the audience area. Explain that you will be calling directions quickly and sometimes there will be more than one group at a place. Start with saying "audience," which is the cue for everyone to sit behind the line. Next, divide the class into four groups. Call these kinds of directions quickly.

- Groups 1 and 4: *Stage Right*
- Group 2: *Stage Left*
- Group 3: *Stage Center*
- Groups 1 and 3: *Audience*